

2026 Dart Throws - The Data's Picks

Six independent statistical screens, each back-tested on 2016-2025 seasons, each looking for cheap late-draft players (\$1-10) with a real shot at mattering. Every screen's track record is stated up front so you can weight them. The ask: does the eye test agree? Which of these names pass the watch-the-games filter, and which are the data fooling itself? (Prices shown are expected auction cost in our 12-team, \$200 keeper league.)

The Handcuff Storm (backup behind a starter in bad-news August)

We scan August news coverage for every team's lead running back. When the starter is drowning in negative headlines (injury talk, decline talk, contract mess) AND his backup is simultaneously getting a spike of public attention, history says that backup pans out about 1 season in 3 - roughly double a normal late flier. The key detail: the bad news alone means nothing. If the backup ISN'T getting attention, those guys hit less than 1 in 10. It takes both halves.

Evan Hull (RB, NO, ~\$1) - His starter Alvin Kamara has 91 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.70 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). *Deep name, but the numbers say what they say: highest breakout score of the storm group.*

Najee Harris (RB, LAC, ~\$2.8) - His starter Omarion Hampton has 21 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.59 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). *A former 1,200-yard workhorse now priced under \$3 behind a rookie who's getting hammered in the news.*

Hassan Haskins (RB, LAC, ~\$1) - His starter Omarion Hampton has 21 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.57 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Will Shipley (RB, PHI, ~\$1) - His starter Saquon Barkley has 77 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.44 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

AJ Dillon (RB, PHI, ~\$1) - His starter Saquon Barkley has 77 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.58 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Terrell Jennings (RB, NE, ~\$1) - His starter TreVeyon Henderson has 27 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.31 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Audric Estimé (RB, NO, ~\$1) - His starter Alvin Kamara has 91 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time.

Robbie Ouzts (RB, SEA, ~\$1) - His starter Kenneth Walker III has 24 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.31 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

D'Ernest Johnson (RB, NE, ~\$1) - His starter TreVeyon Henderson has 27 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Breakout score 0.74 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Devin Singletary (RB, NYG, ~\$1) - His starter Cam Skattebo has 123 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Surged +8.3

points/game in the second half of last season.

Tyrone Tracy Jr. (RB, NYG, ~\$2.7) - His starter Cam Skattebo has 123 August news articles with a clearly negative tone, and this backup's own public attention is spiking at the same time. Surged +8.2 points/game in the second half of last season.

The Price Model (breakout odds from a decade of auction history)

A statistical model trained on ten years of cheap players: age, draft pedigree, how their team's depth chart opened up, late-season usage trends, and what the market pays for that profile. The percentage is the model's estimate that the player returns a startable fantasy season. Players scored this high have historically hit about 1 in 4.

Jerry Jeudy (WR, CLE, ~\$3.8) - The price model gives him a 41% shot at a startable season.

Omar Cooper Jr. (WR, NYJ, ~\$8.4) - The price model gives him a 39% shot at a startable season. Rookie-hit score 0.65 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). *Our single highest-rated young dart. Preseason usage backs it up: 12-yard average target depth - real downfield work, not garbage-time dump-offs.*

Nathaniel Dell (WR, HOU, ~\$2.7) - The price model gives him a 38% shot at a startable season. Weekly ceiling around 14 points when it clicks.

Rashod Bateman (WR, BAL, ~\$2.5) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.49 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Matthew Golden (WR, GB, ~\$3.2) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.59 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). *Eye-test caution flag: only 1 target on 11 preseason routes while Christian Watson caught 4 of 5 sharing the field - the one screen where his arrow points down.*

Zach Ertz (TE, WAS, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season.

Adonai Mitchell (WR, NYJ, ~\$1.3) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.81 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). His team's WR2 job is genuinely open.

Blake Corum (RB, LA, ~\$5.1) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.38 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Out-produced his starter per touch last year, though the starter is young/locked-in, which historically slows the takeover. Surged +4.9 points/game in the second half of last season. *The model's overall #1 dart: LA's clear next man up, with camp attention rising.*

Malik Washington (WR, MIA, ~\$2.7) - The price model gives him a 36% shot at a startable season.

Tre Harris (WR, LAC, ~\$1.6) - The price model gives him a 35% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.66 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Xavier Legette (WR, CAR, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 35% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.51 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Germie Bernard (WR, PIT, ~\$9.5) - The price model gives him a 35% shot at a startable season. Rookie-hit score 0.43 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%).

Andrei Iosivas (WR, CIN, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 34% shot at a startable season.

Rashid Shaheed (WR, SEA, ~\$4) - The price model gives him a 34% shot at a startable season.

Buried Talent (elite per-play skill stuck in a bad spot)

We grade every player's per-play skill adjusted for opponent quality - basically 'how good is he when the ball comes his way, regardless of volume.' Players in the top 20% of that grade who are still somehow cheap have been the best STAR-finder we have: about 1 in 6 becomes a genuine league-winner, six times the base rate for cheap players.

Sam LaPorta (TE, DET, ~\$8.6) - Per-play skill grade in the 91th percentile league-wide - elite ability, bargain price. *Was TE3-overall as a rookie two years ago; the market has over-corrected on one down-ish year.*

Tucker Kraft (TE, GB, ~\$9.8) - Per-play skill grade in the 82th percentile league-wide - elite ability, bargain price. *Also appears in the 2025 Flash screen (21.7 ppg best month) - two independent screens agree.*

Heir Apparent (backups who outplayed their own starter)

Backups who out-produced their team's starter per touch last season. About 1 in 3 of these take over the job within a year - and it jumps way higher when the starter is 29+ on an expiring contract, and drops when the starter is young and locked in. TAKEOVER is the stronger flavor: a clear talent gap over the incumbent, which has led to a job change 58% of the time.

Tank Bigsby (RB, PHI, ~\$3.3) - The price model gives him a 33% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.80 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Talent-gap takeover flag: he's simply better than the guy ahead of him (58% of these have taken the job). *Sits behind a 29-year-old Saquon Barkley on an expiring deal - the exact profile (Ingram-to-Kamara, Stewart-to-McCaffrey) that has minted starters.*

Blake Corum (RB, LA, ~\$5.1) - The price model gives him a 37% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.38 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Out-produced his starter per touch last year, though the starter is young/locked-in, which historically slows the takeover. Surged +4.9 points/game in the second half of last season. *The model's overall #1 dart: LA's clear next man up, with camp attention rising.*

Devin Neal (RB, NO, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 10% shot at a startable season. Out-produced his starter per touch last year, and that starter is old and/or on an expiring deal - the highest-rate takeover setup we track. Surged +8.7 points/game in the second half of last season. *Behind 31-year-old Alvin Kamara - and note Kamara also shows up in the news-storm screen.*

Keaton Mitchell (RB, LAC, ~\$2.7) - Breakout score 0.31 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Out-produced his starter per touch last year, though the starter is young/locked-in, which historically slows the takeover. Surged +2.5 points/game in the second half of last season. *Now in LAC behind rookie Omarion Hampton - electric per-touch numbers before his 2024 injury, and Hampton is the news-storm screen's most negative starter.*

Zach Charbonnet (RB, SEA, ~\$5.5) - Talent-gap takeover flag: he's simply better than the guy ahead of him (58% of these have taken the job). *Per-touch he has outplayed Kenneth Walker for two years; Walker is also in a news storm - but note Charbonnet's own public buzz is quiet this August, which historically matters (see the storm section).*

Samaje Perine (RB, CIN, ~\$1.5) - The price model gives him a 21% shot at a startable season. Out-produced his starter per touch last year, though the starter is young/locked-in, which historically slows the takeover. Surged +3.3 points/game in the second half of last season. *Passing-down veteran behind Chase Brown in Cincinnati.*

Camp Buzz (August Wikipedia attention spikes)

We track Wikipedia page views for every player and flag whoever is being looked up way more this August than their own normal. On dollar-bin players this is shockingly predictive - the crowd collectively notices camp risers before the market prices them (Puka Nacua's August 2023 spike was in the 98th percentile before he had played a snap). Important: this ONLY works on cheap players. Attention on expensive players is just hype.

Malachi Corley (WR, CLE, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.48 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 19x his own normal baseline.

Jalen Brooks (WR, ARI, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.40 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 15x his own normal baseline.

Trayveon Williams (RB, CLE, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.34 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 9x his own normal baseline.

Corey Kiner (RB, ARI, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.65 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 9x his own normal baseline.

Jayden Higgins (WR, HOU, ~\$2.3) - Breakout score 0.71 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Surged +4.5 points/game in the second half of last season. August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 8x his own normal baseline. *Houston rookie also flagged by preseason data watchers; buzz plus a real second-half surge.*

Jimmy Horn Jr. (WR, CAR, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 16% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.31 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 7x his own normal baseline.

Tyler Goodson (RB, IND, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.57 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 7x his own normal baseline.

Khalil Herbert (RB, NYJ, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.42 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Surged +1.6 points/game in the second half of last season. August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 7x his own normal baseline.

Dylan Laube (RB, LV, ~\$1) - August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 7x his own normal baseline.

Myles Price (WR, MIN, ~\$1) - August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 6x his own normal baseline.

Darius Cooper (WR, PHI, ~\$1) - August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 6x his own normal baseline.

Malik Davis (RB, DAL, ~\$1) - The price model gives him a 20% shot at a startable season. Breakout score 0.41 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Surged +5.5 points/game in the second half of last season. August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 6x his own normal baseline.

Hassan Haskins (RB, LAC, ~\$1) - Breakout score 0.57 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 6x his own normal baseline.

Colson Yankoff (TE, WAS, ~\$1) - August Wikipedia lookups are running roughly 6x his own normal baseline.

The 2025 Flash (already did it, market forgot)

Young players (25 or younger) who had a legitimately hot month last season - a best-4-week stretch of 12+ points a game - but are priced like nothing happened. In back-testing this simple screen keeps finding real contributors the market writes off.

Michael Wilson (WR, ARI, ~\$6.9) - Surged +14.2 points/game in the second half of last season. Weekly ceiling around 14 points when it clicks. Averaged 28.4 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Wan'Dale Robinson (WR, TEN, ~\$10) - Averaged 25.4 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

RJ Harvey (RB, DEN, ~\$5.6) - Surged +3.1 points/game in the second half of last season. Averaged 22.4 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Tucker Kraft (TE, GB, ~\$9.8) - Per-play skill grade in the 82th percentile league-wide - elite ability, bargain price. Averaged 21.7 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025. *Also appears in the 2025 Flash screen (21.7 ppg best month) - two independent screens agree.*

Troy Franklin (WR, DEN, ~\$1.5) - Breakout score 0.40 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Averaged 21.7 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Quentin Johnston (WR, LAC, ~\$5.5) - Weekly ceiling around 14 points when it clicks. Averaged 21.2 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Zach Charbonnet (RB, SEA, ~\$5.5) - Talent-gap takeover flag: he's simply better than the guy ahead of him (58% of these have taken the job). Averaged 20.5 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025. *Per-touch he has outplayed Kenneth Walker for two years; Walker is also in a news storm - but note Charbonnet's own public buzz is quiet this August, which historically matters (see the storm section).*

Tre Tucker (WR, LV, ~\$2) - Averaged 20.2 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Kimani Vidal (RB, LAC, ~\$2.4) - Averaged 20.2 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Jacory Croskey-Merritt (RB, WAS, ~\$5.4) - Averaged 19.8 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Romeo Doubs (WR, NE, ~\$4.2) - Averaged 19.6 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

Woody Marks (RB, HOU, ~\$3.1) - Averaged 18.7 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025. *Houston's murky backfield just lost Nick Chubb to retirement - the path keeps clearing.*

Marvin Harrison Jr. (WR, ARI, ~\$7.9) - Breakout score 0.73 - top of the cheap pool (the top fifth of these scores hits ~24%). Averaged 18.4 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025. *The market has capitulated to ~\$8 on a former #4 overall pick with an 18-point best month as a rookie.*

Kayshon Boutte (WR, NE, ~\$1.7) - Averaged 18.1 points/game over his best four weeks of 2025.

The fine print (also part of the eye test)

Base rates: cheap darts mostly miss - even our best screens hit 25-50%, not 80%. A name on multiple lists (Corum, Charbonnet, Hassan Haskins, Tucker Kraft) is a stronger signal than any single screen. Deliberate omissions: backups behind news-storm starters who have NO public buzz of their own (Charbonnet, Jam Miller, Kendre Miller, Antonio Gibson) are NOT picks - that exact profile hit under 1-in-10 historically. And one honest research note: preseason box-score hype (viral catches, rookie target spam, yards per carry for veterans) tested as pure noise - the only preseason numbers with signal are target depth, veteran target-earning rates, and rookie rushing efficiency paired with draft capital.